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The Body as a Battlefield and Instrument of War, Technique, and Embodied Memory in Akram Khan's Xenos

This paper reads *Xenos* as a choreographic analysis of how colonial war organizes bodies in a foreign land. The Akram Khan Company frames *Xenos* as taking place "on the border between East and West, past and present, mythology and technology" (Akram Khan Company) because the work makes borders and politics bodily, not only geographic and historical. I analyze how *Xenos* produces meaning through shifts between Kathak-trained technique and contemporary movement language. Kathak rhythm, footwork, turning, and tempo play can read as a skilled artistic choice through the dancer's command of timing, attention, and precision. As contemporary movement takes over, the choreography becomes heavier and more repetitive, and the same control begins to resemble enforced endurance, as if the body is being pushed to function under war's demands.

My method combines close choreographic analysis with attention to scenography, sound, and repetition, read through four course frameworks: Michel Foucault's account of discipline as a technology that increases bodily utility while intensifying obedience (Foucault 138), Judith Butler's argument in *Bodies That Matter* that bodies materialize under regulatory norms through reiterated practice (Butler 2), Royona Mitra's critique of intercultural power asymmetries shaping how South Asian trained bodies become legible within contemporary dance discourse

(Mitra 7), and Susan Leigh Foster's questions for reading choreography as a politics of agency, training, and witnessing in "Choreographies of Protest" (Foster 397). This paper is also informed by my experience of watching Akram Khan perform *Xenos* live in India in 2023, an encounter that sharpened my sense of why the work matters so deeply in a global context. My central claim is that *Xenos* shows how colonial war can reframe a trained dancing body as labour and endurance without erasing lineage, which continues to surface through rhythmic structure and technique.

Introduction

Trained technique onstage is often received as a sign of freedom because virtuosity appears self-directed, precise, and intentionally chosen. Xenos unsettles that assumption by placing a trained diasporic dancing body inside a colonial war frame, where endurance, obedience to tempo, and repeated effort become integral forms of value. Moving between Kathak-trained technique and contemporary movement language, the work stages a tension between lineage as selfhood and war as a system that reorganises bodies for use.

Xenos, meaning "stranger" or "foreigner," is Akram Khan's final full-length solo performance work. The Akram Khan Company describes it as drawing on "the archives of the 20th century" to "give voice to the shell-shocked dream of a colonial soldier in the First World War," centring "an Indian dancer whose skilled body becomes an instrument of war" (Akram Khan Company). The title matters because foreignness in the work is not only geographic. It becomes bodily, historical, and political: foreign to home, foreign to empire, and at times even foreign to oneself. That frame also matters materially. The First World War was not only a European catastrophe but an imperial system that mobilised South Asian bodies on a vast scale.

Around 1.5 million men from the Indian Army served during the war, and more than 74,000 from undivided India died (Onassis Foundation). Read against that scale of mobilisation and loss, Khan's dancing body does not stand in for war abstractly; it condenses a larger history of racialised labour, displacement, and uneven remembrance.

The Akram Khan Company's description is revealing not only for what it claims but for what it compresses. The figure onstage is introduced under the broad rubric of an "Indian dancer," yet the choreographic voice of the work is shaped by Khan's diasporic positioning as a British Bangladeshi artist trained in the North Indian classical form of Kathak and in Western contemporary dance (Mitra 7). Mitra describes Khan as a "second-generation Muslim, British-Bangladeshi dancer choreographer" whose oeuvre emerges at the "interstices of his diasporic identity positions" (Mitra 7). Khan's positioning is also biographical: he was born and raised in London in a family with roots in Dhaka, began dancing through Bengali folk forms guided by his mother, and entered Kathak training at age seven with Sri Pratap Pawar (Roy; Jaggi). He is frequently received in global arts circuits under flattened categories such as "Indian choreographer" or "South Asian," and *Xenos* tests exactly that instability of naming: how a body is read across contexts, and how quickly it can be made foreign to the empire it serves, to the nation it is used to represent, and even to the categories through which audiences try to make it legible.

This dynamic also places *Xenos* within Khan's broader body of work, which repeatedly returns to borders, displacement, and cultural memory. In that sense, *Xenos* does not arrive as a sudden political turn, but as a culmination: a final solo that gathers earlier preoccupations into the figure of the soldier as foreigner. My point of entry, then, is the trained body as a site where history becomes sensation and political friction. I read the work through its shifting mental and

physical states, including control, alertness, estrangement, panic, fatigue, and breakdown, to show how colonial war can reframe a dancing body as labour and endurance without ever fully erasing lineage.

Method

Methodologically, I use close choreographic analysis grounded in primary and reputable sources, including production materials and documentation, and I contextualise the performance's war frame through historical scholarship on the First World War mobilisation of the British Indian Army and associated labour. Theoretical frames for this analysis include Michel Foucault, *Discipline and Punish*; Judith Butler, *Bodies That Matter*; Royona Mitra, "Unmaking Contact: Choreographic Touch at the Intersections of Race, Caste, and Gender"; and Susan Leigh Foster, "Choreographies of Protest." I bring these readings into direct contact with specific scenes and choreographic choices.

This paper is written from a place that is both scholarly and personally invested. *Xenos* offers a medium through which colonial war history extends beyond historical documentation and returns as embodied memory and sensory communication. This work insists that history is not only known but carried and rescripted in and through the body.

Choreographic Analysis

I analyze how *Xenos* produces meaning through Kathak-trained technique and contemporary movement language in four stages of transformation. Each stage alters the dancer's relationship to rhythm, gravity, sound, and material space: first as cultural performance grounded in Kathak lineage, then as physical endurance shaped by military terrain, then as

archival confrontation with the erased histories of colonial soldiers, and finally as burial within a landscape where life and death remain unresolved.

Part One: Remembered Grace and Lineage

My observations here draw both on published reviews and on my own experience of watching Akram Khan perform *Xenos* live in India in 2023. Reviewers note that the piece begins as a cultural event, cast as a wedding scene in which a Kathak dancer is expected to entertain, with a stage picture that is both celebratory and unstable (Jennings; Watts). Khan himself frames this opening as a return to classical practice, calling it "a mini classical concert," with Indian musicians singing as the audience enters (Wiegand). Dramaturgically, the opening functions not as a mere prelude, but as an origin: it gives the audience a living sense of lineage, rhythm, and artistic intelligence before war reorganises them.

Khan's vocabulary here is anchored in Kathak's relationship to taal, the cyclical rhythmic framework that structures time in North Indian classical music and dance. Through *tatkar*, or footwork, he does not simply move with rhythm but produces it, making timing both visible and audible. In Kathak, this is not ornamental sound but an embodied way of thinking through *laya* (tempo) and *layakari* (rhythmic play), as patterns shift speed without losing structure.

At the same time, the opening is not sealed within a purely classical frame. Alongside Kathak, traces of contemporary movement appear in the more elastic use of torso, breath, and transition, allowing the body to move through weight rather than only punctuate time against it. This is important to my argument because the opening already establishes a multiply trained body: Kathak gives the dancer rhythmic authority, while contemporary movement expands his expressive register and prepares the body for later theatrical transformation under war.

The company's production materials list five onstage musicians, including BC Manjunath on percussion and *konnakol*, Aditya Prakash on vocals, Nina Harries on double bass and vocals, Fra Rustumji on violin, and Tamar Osborn on baritone saxophone (Akram Khan Company). That instrumentation matters because it places multiple sonic languages in the space at once, so Khan's timing reads as exchange rather than solitary display. His body seems to listen, answer, and anticipate, making rhythm feel like a shared field of thought rather than accompaniment alone. This is also where Mitra's critique of intercultural legibility sharpens the analysis. In contemporary dance discourse, South Asian technique is often expected to render itself intelligible through simplified translation, as if its value depends on being quickly understood within dominant frameworks (Mitra 7). *Xenos* resists that demand by refusing to reduce Kathak to a simplified form. Instead, it presents classical structure as an embodied logic with its own density and temporal authority. The presence of contemporary movement complicates that legibility further: rather than making Kathak easier to digest, Khan lets both movement languages coexist, asking the audience to encounter a body carrying multiple histories of training at once.

Part 2: The Body Under Command

The piece intensifies as the opening's rhythmic precision and grounded control begin to fracture, replaced by a body that appears increasingly interrupted, off-balance, and under pressure. Reviewers describe the elegant social space of the opening gradually giving way to a trench world shaped by unstable electricity, mud, and threat (Anderson; Jennings). In performance, this shift registered as a corruption of atmosphere: the warm wedding light flickered and hardened into something harsher, while the earlier continuity of precise footwork, circular turns, and measured pacing broke into pauses, jolts, and irregular bursts of movement.

As light and sound became unstable, the body could no longer sustain the composure of the ceremonial space; instead, it moved through interruption and instability, as though the wedding and the trench had begun to occupy the stage at once.

This is where contemporary movement language becomes crucial. The body drops lower, weight grows heavier, the spine yields into collapse, and recovery becomes effortful rather than clean. The choreography turns toward recoil, crawling, rolling, and repeated attempts to rise, so that the audience witnesses not only technique but the cost of continuing. This matters to my argument because the same trained clarity that earlier read as artistic choice now begins to resemble enforced endurance: the body remains expressive, but it is increasingly pressured by an external system.

Jennings describes the percussion as becoming the "reports from a sniper's rifle" (Jennings). That sonic shift marks a crucial hinge in the choreography. The dancer remains technically capable, but technique no longer reads as self-directed. Instead, it begins to look reactive: a body listening for danger, bracing for impact, and responding under pressure. What emerges is hypervigilance and disorientation, as if the soldier's mental warfare has entered the musculature itself.

The set concretises this conversion of artistry into labour. Mirella Weingarten's design is described as a steep sloping wall that later becomes the dancer's world boundary, a rampart of earthworks and no man's land (Anderson; Jennings). The slope removes the neutral ground on which dance can appear freely chosen. Every ascent seems like hauling, and every descent like a loss of control. In my own viewing, this was one of the most striking choreographic

transformations in the piece: Khan could still turn, roll, and recover, but those same capacities now seemed governed by gravity, strain, and risk rather than by compositional freedom alone.

As the choreography turns from ceremonial control toward repeated physical struggle, Foucault's account of discipline becomes especially illuminating. He describes a technology that increases bodily utility while intensifying obedience (Foucault 138). In *Xenos*, the repeated climbing and tumbling do more than evoke battle. They stage the making of a body conditioned for endurance. Under these conditions, even finely honed capacities such as timing and precision begin to read as utility, recast by the surrounding world as productive output (Foucault 138).

This is also the point at which the dancer's relationship to the musicians seems to change. In the live performance, they felt more elevated and distant, visible overhead less as collaborators than as remote witnesses presiding over his fate. What began in the opening as an intimate exchange gradually took on the quality of exposure or judgment. Music was no longer co-authored, but became an external condition through which the body had to move and which it could no longer fully shape for itself.

Part Three: Cable, Gramophone, and a Haunted Record

This section of *Xenos* turns from physical struggle toward haunted repetition, framing the soldier's experience as temporally unstable, caught between then and now, and unable to keep the past contained. The gramophone scene becomes a crucial archival turning point in the work. As Anderson notes, the giant gramophone horn turns toward Khan "like a gun sighting him," voicing the names of Indian soldiers and fragments of their labour, including the laying of telephone wires (Anderson). The scene shifts the performance from atmosphere into historical specificity, making colonial labour audible rather than leaving it implied in the background.

Anderson also describes the accompanying voice as invoking “voices in the mud” and repeating that “half of them are already dead” (Anderson).

That act of naming does not function as neutral historical information. In the live performance I attended, it felt more like an inescapable loop: the repeated calling of names and tasks seemed to press against Khan’s body so that he could not move beyond it. Pacing, interruption, agitation, and failed attempts at disconnection accumulated until the archive no longer felt like something recalled from a distance, but like a force acting directly in the present. Choreographically, this is also where contemporary movement language becomes especially important. The body no longer projects rhythmic authority in the same way; it looks increasingly caught in repetition, dragged into pacing, recoil, and effortful return. That shift matters to my argument because the same trained body that earlier seemed self-structuring now appears organized by forces outside itself. This is the point at which the archive becomes kinetic.

Butler’s argument about materialisation helps clarify why this scene is more than commemoration. She argues that bodies materialize under regulatory norms through reiterated practice over time (Butler 2). In *Xenos*, the colonial soldier’s body is produced through repetition and constraint: crawling, falling, rising, looping cables, and re-entering the same task space again and again. The gramophone’s repetition of “already dead” performs the brutal logic by which certain bodies are made historically disposable. The soldier becomes something that can be used and then buried, both literally and narratively.

This is also the moment at which Foster’s emphasis on spectatorship becomes unavoidable. The stage becomes an image of no man’s land held under a harsh beam, with a searchlight scanning the space and reframing performance as surveillance rather than theatre

(Jennings). Foster asks us to consider the relationship bodies establish with those watching and the way choreography produces politics through training, action, and witnessing (Foster 397). In *Xenos*, the searchlight organizes a way of looking that belongs to war. The audience is no longer simply watching a dancer, but is implicated in a structure of observation that exposes a body under command.

Khan explicitly frames this reliance on bodily narration as both an aesthetic and cultural decision. He explains that he worked with dramaturg Ruth Little and writer Jordan Tannahill toward reducing text because "the action of the story had to be told by the body, not by the words" (Wiegand). That choice is not an anti-textual gesture. It insists that the soldier's experience cannot be safely contained within explanation alone, and that the body must carry what history so often refuses to carry in public memory.

Part Four: Avalanche, Burial, and Contaminated Rebirth

In the final section, the stage becomes physically hostile: debris pours down the slope, stable ground disappears, and the body is forced to negotiate with matter itself. The slope becomes a burial site, and multiple accounts describe the stage filling with debris, including pine cones that initially read as rocks or artillery remnants (Traiger). Anderson describes "clods of mud" skittering down until Khan is overwhelmed, framing the ending as "a man returning to earth, a dancer becoming clay" (Anderson). Khan himself echoes this elemental return, describing the last scene as one in which "clay is all over my body and earth lies across the stage," explicitly naming it as "about rebirth" (Wiegand).

Choreographically, this is also where contemporary movement language reaches an extreme. The body is no longer shaping the space with rhythmic authority, but struggling to

survive within it. Weight drops fully into matter, balance becomes precarious, and movement is reorganised around instability, interruption, and effortful continuation. That matters to my argument because the body now appears almost fully claimed by external conditions: what began as trained choice has become the labour of enduring terrain, debris, and collapse. The avalanche can be read as a grenade, shrapnel, or mine, but also as organic matter that suggests burial and uneasy regrowth. That instability marks the final stage of mental warfare: not only panic or fatigue, but the sense that even survival is contaminated by what has been endured.

Foster's concept of bodily interference is useful here. In her framing, protest is a physical strategy of interruption that reorganises space and forces attention (Foster 397). The avalanche functions in that way: it interrupts the stage, overwhelms the performer's control, and in some stagings threatens to spill into the audience's space, collapsing the safe distance between spectator and war. In a work built around who is seen and who is forgotten, this material overflow becomes a choreographic refusal. It refuses to let war remain representational and makes it tactile.

Khan states that the work is a reflection of how he feels about the world today and describes it as confronting a "loss of humanity" through past and present wars (Akram Khan Company, *Xenos* 2). The final burial into earth and clay, therefore, functions as more than a metaphor, as it becomes a warning about extraction, disposability, and the ongoing conversion of bodies into instruments.

Conclusion

What makes *Xenos* endure beyond its final image is that it situates the colonial soldier within Khan's larger artistic vantage point as a diasporic performer whose work has long returned to borders, fracture, memory, and belonging. Seen in that wider arc, *Xenos* is not only about one war or one soldier, but about the repeated making of the outsider body: the racialised body that can be admired for its skill, pressed into service, and then left at the edge of remembrance. That is why the work feels so urgent in the present. In a world still shaped by militarised labour, displacement, and geopolitical violence, *Xenos* asks how quickly a body can become alien to the systems that use it. Dance matters here precisely because it resists desensitisation and it returns abstraction to flesh, tempo, and effort, and makes the cost of history visible again. What stayed with me most was the depth of research and care that shaped *Xenos*, especially its commitment to histories that are so often narrated without the body.

The First World War is not unfamiliar to me as a subject, as it is widely studied in India. But experiencing it through dance altered my understanding of it, because movement made its human cost feel immediate in a way that historical narration alone could not. This project is especially meaningful to me because Akram Khan helped shape my sense of what a classically Indian-trained body can carry onto global stages. As one of the most influential choreographers working internationally today, Khan has helped redefine how contemporary dance can hold classical lineage, diasporic identity, and political memory within the same body.

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